

including angina and low blood pressure, and is often given as a tonic during recovery from a heart attack. In the Caribbean, the juice of the whole plant is used to expel worms, and the stems and flowers are used in the treatment of rheumatism.

⚠ Cautions Take only under professional supervision. Excessive doses may cause stomach upset and hallucinations.



Night-blooming cereus has spectacular flowers that open at dusk and close at dawn.

Sempervivum tectorum (Crassulaceae) Houseleek

Description Succulent perennial growing to 4 in (10 cm). Has round rosettes of leaves, and flowering stems bearing clusters of bell-shaped red flowers.



Houseleek's succulent leaves contain tannins and mucilage, both soothing to the skin.

Habitat & Cultivation The herb is native to central and southern Europe and now grows wild in northern Europe, North Africa, and western Asia, preferring sandy dry soil. Houseleek is widely cultivated as a garden plant. The leaves are picked in summer.

Parts Used Leaves, leaf juice.

Constituents Houseleek contains polyphenols, including procyanidins and mucilage.

History & Folklore The Frankish King Charlemagne (742–814 CE) told his subjects to plant houseleek on their roofs, as the plant reputedly warded off lightning and fire.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Houseleek leaves and their juice are used for their cooling and astringent effect, being applied externally to soothe many skin conditions, including burns, wounds, boils, and corns. As with many other remedies that are both astringent and soothing, houseleek simultaneously tightens and softens the skin. Traditionally, the leaves have been chewed to relieve toothache, and the juice has been sniffed to stop nosebleeds. Houseleek is still used externally, but internal use of this herb is not advised because in large doses it will induce vomiting.

Caution Do not take houseleek internally.

Senecio aureus syn. Packera aurea Life Root, Squaw Weed

Description Upright perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has lance-shaped leaves and clusters of yellow daisy-type flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to eastern North America, life root is found in marshes, and on damp ground and riverbanks. The aerial parts are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Life root contains a volatile oil, pyrrolizidine alkaloids (including senecine, senecionine, and otosenine), tannins, and resin. In isolation, the pyrrolizidine alkaloids are highly toxic to the liver.

History & Folklore The North American Catawba people used life root to treat gynecological problems in general, and to relieve labor pains in particular.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Until recently, life root was employed in Anglo-American herbalism much as it was in earlier times—as a means to induce menstrual periods and to bring relief to menopausal complaints. Today, the plant is recommended only for external use, as a douche for excessive vaginal discharge.

Related Species Ragwort (*S. jacobaea*) has traditionally been used as a poultice or lotion to relieve rheumatic aches and pains.

Cautions Do not take life root internally. The plant is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Sesamum indicum (Pedaliaceae) Sesame, Hei Zhi Ma

Description Erect annual growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has lance-shaped to oval leaves, white, pink, or mauve flowers, and oblong seed capsules bearing many small gray seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Africa, sesame is cultivated in tropical and subtropical areas around the world. The root is unearthed in summer; the seeds are collected after the seed capsules have turned brown-black.



Sesame seeds are a rich source of unsaturated fatty acids and calcium.

Parts Used Seeds, seed oil, root.

Constituents The seeds are highly nutritious and contain about 55% oil (mainly polyunsaturated fats), about 20% protein, lignans (notably sesamin and sesamol), vitamins B₃ and E, and minerals. The lignans are thought to lower blood cholesterol levels and blood pressure.

History & Folklore Sesame was one of the plants found in the tomb of Tutankhamun